

Chapter 78-2

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As it turned out, three days ago, the people Father Liang had sent to search for their daughter had found a lead, and it happened to match with the girl searching for her family online.

If she had been in a state of no contact, they might not have found her this quickly.

But Guo Xinran had stirred up quite a commotion online. If the Liang family members had bothered to look at those "useless" social media platforms, they might have seen it much earlier.

After learning Guo Xinran's specific address, the Liang parents drove early in the morning to that remote place.

It took over nine hours to drive there from Haizhou City, so by the time they met her, it was already approaching evening. Apparently, when they arrived, Guo Xinran was rolling up her sleeves to slaughter a chicken.

The place where she lived was shabby and run-down. The ground was muddy from the recent rain, and the Liang couple's eyes welled up with tears just looking at it.

Looking at that face that bore such a striking resemblance to Qiu Zimin's when she was young, they could almost certainly conclude that this was their daughter who had been lost for twenty-five years.

But to be safe, they still took Guo Xinran to the provincial capital hospital for a DNA test.

With today's advanced technology, the test results could come out in just two hours.

So Qiu Zimin shared this news with everyone in the group chat. None of the people waiting for news at the Liang family's old residence had a happy expression on their faces.

Even the usually kind and generous Sun Meirou couldn't find words to comfort everyone.

That very day, Liang Xinzhou had intended to pack up and move out, but Liang Xinhe persuaded him not to upset their parents too much. He said they should wait until their parents brought her back, take a look at their biological sister first, and then make a decision—after all, there were blood ties involved.

Liang Wanwan had also returned from school. She had always been quiet and reserved, and that day she joined Liang Xinhe in persuading him. In the end, Liang Xinzhou didn't manage to move out.

However, they were also in a state of quietly waiting for news.

Guo Xinran still had matters to handle over there, so it would be another two days before she could return.

Father Liang had dropped all the company's affairs and gone straight to the small village thousands of miles away.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe had no choice but to help with the aftermath.

The first thing that needed to be dealt with was that Guo Xinran had signed with Zuoye Culture. The contract had just been signed, requiring her to livestream her mountain village life.

But now that Guo Xinran had successfully reunited with her biological family, she naturally wouldn't stay in that small mountain village anymore. However, the person in charge on the other side was unwilling to let her go. When Father Liang learned of this matter, he wanted Guo Xinran to terminate her contract with Zuoye Culture.

The person at Zuoye Culture responsible for this matter had just returned from that godforsaken place in the middle of nowhere¹. When he learned about this, he was furious and threatened over the phone to take Guo Xinran to court.

How could the Liang couple, eager to protect their daughter, allow him to say such things?

So Father Liang said harshly, "Go ahead and sue. I'd like to see just how capable you are."

Zuoye Culture had no idea that Guo Xinran's biological parents were the renowned president of Dongheng Group, and directly contacted their lawyers.

Meanwhile, Father Liang called Liang Xinhe from thousands of miles away, telling him to make sure this matter was handled properly.

Liang Xinhe was also at a loss, but upon hearing that the other party had already sent a lawyer's letter, he could only agree under the pressure from his parents.

He had looked into Zuoye Culture—it was just an unknown livestreaming company with a registered capital of only one million yuan. The CEO was an internet celebrity who had made their fortune through livestream e-commerce. It wasn't any big company.

Normally, the way Liang Xinhe and his family would handle this would be to simply acquire the company.

But Liang Xinhe was unwilling to acquire it. The entertainment industry was notoriously difficult to manage, and their family already had Haicheng Culture, which was developing steadily. They didn't need an extra company.

The best method would be to pay ten million yuan in breach-of-contract penalties and be done with it.

Liang Xinhe was also unwilling to do that.

This sister hadn't even come back yet, and they were already supposed to fork out ten million yuan. No matter how you looked at it, something seemed fishy.

So he chose a more troublesome method that didn't require spending money or using their people.

But just as he started working on it, Liang Xinzhou found out.

Liang Xinhe looked confused. "Can't I help?"

Liang Xinzhou said in a deep voice, "You can, but we should wait until we've met her first. Besides, if you make such a big fuss about it, wouldn't that let everyone know we're helping an internet celebrity?"

"Internet celebrity?" Liang Xinhe was stunned. "She..."

"Someone who rose to fame through online livestreaming and continues to live in that kind of place putting on a show even after having the financial means to leave." Liang Xinzhou sneered. "If she's not an internet celebrity, then what is she?"

"But still..." Liang Xinhe wavered a bit, stammering, "You don't have to put it that way."

"She currently has a hundred thousand followers on Weibo and has done product promotions." Liang Xinzhou placed the tablet in his hands in front of him. "She has seven hundred thousand followers on the Yumao livestreaming platform. Many of her videos have over a hundred thousand likes, and her monthly income is at least thirty thousand yuan."

He laid out the real data one by one. "And she's only been doing this for less than half a year. Without someone pushing her from behind the scenes, how could she have accumulated so many followers in such a short time?"

Liang Xinhe froze, pursed his lips, and sighed. "I forgot about that."

"Instead of digging up dirt on artists under Zuoye Culture, you might as well investigate whether she's secretly colluding with people from Zuoye Culture." Liang Xinzhou said, "This looks a lot like a 'pig-butcher' scam."²

Liang Xinhe: "?"

"Pig-butcher scam?" Liang Xinhe was shocked. "What do you mean?"

"It's when two or more parties join forces to commit fraud," Liang Xinzhou said.

"No way?" Liang Xinhe was still somewhat incredulous. "She's just a farm girl who grew up in the countryside. Besides, she didn't even know our family was this wealthy, and that we would happen to reunite with her at this particular time."

"So isn't it possible that she originally didn't plan to scam us, but we just happened to walk right into it?" Liang Xinzhou adjusted his glasses, and suddenly winced, sucking in a sharp breath from the pain.

Only then did Liang Shi notice that there was a red scab on the lower part of his right eyelid.

It looked like a fresh scratch.

1. The original Chinese expression "雞不拉屎鳥不生蛋" literally means "a place where chickens don't defecate and birds don't lay eggs"—a colorful way to describe an extremely remote and desolate location. ⇐
2. "Pig-butchering scam" (殺豬盤) is a type of fraud where scammers build trust with their victims over time (like "fattening a pig") before executing the scam (the "butchering"). In this context, Liang Xinzhou suspects that Guo Xinran and Zuoye Culture might be working together in a coordinated scheme to defraud the Liang family. ⇐